Saul, David, and a Forever King

1 Samuel 8; 15–17; 2 Samuel 7; 11–12

The big idea: Israel wanted a king like the nations and got Saul. God, who looks on the heart, chose David, who fought as Israel's champion and received God's promise of a throne that would last forever. David fell and was forgiven, and the promise pointed beyond him to Jesus, the Son of David whose kingdom has no end.

Before you meet: Read

1 Samuel 8:4–20 · 1 Samuel 16:1–13 · 1 Samuel 17:32–52 · 2 Samuel 7:1–17 · 2 Samuel 12:1–14; Psalm 51

Open (5 minutes)

When you were growing up, who did you want to be like? Why?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Now appoint for us a king to judge us like all the _____." *(1 Samuel 8:5)*

"Behold, to _____ is better than sacrifice, and to listen than the fat of rams." *(1 Samuel 15:22)*

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the _____." *(1 Samuel 16:7)*

"For the battle is the _____, and he will give you into our hand." *(1 Samuel 17:47)*

"Your _____ shall be established _____." *(2 Samuel 7:16)*

"Create in me a clean _____, O God, and renew a right spirit within me." *(Psalm 51:10)*

Discuss

1. Israel wanted a king like all the nations. Why was that a rejection of God? Where are you tempted to want to be like everyone else? *1 Samuel 8:5–7, 19–20*

2. Saul looked like a king, and David looked like a shepherd boy. What does 1 Samuel 16:7 say about how God chooses and how we judge? *1 Samuel 16:6–13*

3. How does it change the Goliath story to see yourself as one of the frightened soldiers rather than as David? *1 Samuel 17:8–11, 51–52*

4. David wanted to build God a house, and God promised to build David a house. Why does that order matter? *2 Samuel 7:1–16*

5. Compare how Saul and David each responded when confronted with sin. What separates real repentance from making excuses? *1 Samuel 15:20–30; 2 Samuel 12:13*

6. Jesus is called the son of David in the first verse of the New Testament. What does it mean to you that his throne lasts forever? *Matthew 1:1; Luke 1:32–33*

Apply this week

Read Psalm 51 each day this week as your own prayer. Name one area where you have been following the crowd instead of God, and one thing God has clearly told you to do that you have only half done. Bring both to him, and thank him for the King who forgives.

Memory verse

"For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 Samuel 16:7

Pray

Confess the ways you have wanted a king like the nations. Pray Psalm 51 for any sin God brings to mind. Thank God for his covenant promise to David, and bow before Jesus, the Son of David, as your King.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 14

Saul, David, and a Forever King

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read 1 Samuel 16:1–13 aloud together. Then read 2 Samuel 7:8–16.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 4, and 5 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Covenant with David chart and the Two Kings comparison in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 15 (1 Kings 3, 8, and 11).

Main points to land

1. Israel's demand for a king like the nations was a rejection of God as their King (1 Samuel 8:7).
2. Saul looked impressive but would not obey. God chose David by looking on the heart (1 Samuel 15:22–23; 16:7).
3. David fought Goliath as Israel's representative champion, a picture of the Son of David who wins the victory his people cannot (1 Samuel 17:8–9, 47; Hebrews 2:14–15).
4. In 2 Samuel 7 God promised David an offspring, a kingdom, a Father-son bond, and a throne forever. This is the covenant of grace narrowing to one royal family.
5. David fell, confessed, and was forgiven, though he faced a Father's discipline. Jesus is the sinless Son of David, raised to reign forever (Acts 2:30–32; Luke 1:32–33).

Answer key (Observe)

1. nations
2. obey
3. heart
4. LORD's
5. throne; forever
6. heart

Questions people will ask

If God wanted Israel to have a king one day, why was asking for one wrong?
God had planned for a king (Deuteronomy 17:14–20), but Israel asked for the wrong reason: to be like the nations, with a king who would fight for them in place of trusting God (1 Samuel 8:5–7, 19–20). The problem was not kingship. It was a heart that wanted security without God.

How can David be called a man after God's own heart after adultery and murder?

The phrase describes God's choice of David and David's heart toward God, not a sinless life (1 Samuel 13:14; Acts 13:22). What set David apart was his repentance. He did not excuse his sin, and Psalm 51 shows a heart broken over it. God forgave him, and David still faced serious discipline.

Was Bathsheba to blame?

The text puts the guilt on David. He saw, sent, and took her (2 Samuel 11:4), used his power as king, and then arranged her husband's death. Nathan's parable places the sin on the rich man, and God says it was David who despised him (2 Samuel 12:9–10). Keep the focus where the text keeps it.

If God forgave David, why did the child die and his family suffer?

Forgiveness removed David's guilt before God: you shall not die (2 Samuel 12:13). The consequences were a Father's discipline, which God had promised in 2 Samuel 7:14 and which Hebrews 12:6 says comes from love. We may not understand every part of it, but God did not take back his forgiveness.

Closing prayer

Father, you see not as man sees. Forgive us for wanting kings like the nations and for making excuses when we sin. Create in us clean hearts. Thank you for your covenant promise to David, kept in Jesus, the Son of David, who fought our battle, forgives our sin, and reigns forever. Make us loyal to our King. Amen.